

EXECUTIVE RESEARCH REPORT

Architecting More Predictable Enterprise Value from Data, Technology and AI Investment

Research and Practical Guidance for Turning Transformation Investment into
Measurable Business Value

Author: Zachary Leifer

Affiliation: State of Mind Strategies

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Executive summary

Most data, digital, and now AI initiatives do not fail because the business case was wrong. They fail because the organization was never adjusted to deliver it. A survey of 82 senior executives found that half or fewer of their organizations' data and digital initiatives fully delivered the commercial outcomes that justified them, and that technology is routinely selected before the business outcome is defined. Initiatives with dedicated ownership and resources were substantially more likely to fully deliver than those treated as an additional responsibility for the business-as-usual team. Not one respondent whose organization had none of five key operating conditions reported full delivery.

Why I studied this problem

Earlier in my career, I was asked to help address complex technology initiatives that had defined objectives but lacked several conditions required for successful execution. Significant resources had been invested in engineering, development and product work, yet the initiatives were incomplete and the expected return had not materialized. When I looked beneath the presentations, much of the rigorous work required to make the vision executable was missing: process maps were incomplete, dependencies were not fully understood, and manual workarounds and tribal knowledge shaped how the work was actually performed.

I assembled a cross-functional team spanning product management, architecture, engineering, business analysis and project management, and went to the front lines. Employees revealed unnecessary workarounds, hidden dependencies and opportunities that were not visible in the executive-level materials. The work also produced a leadership lesson: existing project leaders needed to participate earlier so they could help shape the solution rather than experience it as a judgment on their prior decisions. Transformation affects ownership, authority, professional identity and internal influence, and those dynamics have to be managed alongside process and technology decisions. AI is the newest major transformation wave, following the internet, big data and broad digitalization. The technology is different, but many of the organizational risks are familiar. That is why I undertook this research.

Research question and hypotheses

What separates data, digital transformation and AI investments that create measurable commercial value from those that do not? The research examined whether several operating conditions, organizational readiness, dedicated ownership, executive sponsorship, incentive alignment and a defined method for measuring value, were present, and whether their presence was associated with fuller delivery of expected outcomes.

Methodology and limitations

This research used a voluntary convenience sample drawn from one senior-executive education cohort. The full AMP 210 cohort at Harvard Business School, approximately 148 participants though cohort membership changed during the program, was invited by direct email between March 16 and April 7, 2026, with at least two reminder messages. Eighty-two respondents completed the survey, an approximate participation rate of 55%. Two follow-up executive interviews were conducted by video, each lasting approximately 30 to 60 minutes in a semi-structured format tailored to the participant's responses.

- The sample was not randomly selected and is not nationally or globally representative.
- Responses were self-reported and may reflect recall, perception and role-based bias.
- The survey was cross-sectional and cannot establish causality.
- Some subgroup analyses rely on small cell counts and are labeled exploratory.
- The meaning of success may vary by organization and initiative.
- Many initiatives were still in progress, which limits final-outcome interpretation.
- The two follow-up interviews were explanatory and not independently representative.
- The research did not validate a numerical risk score or universal success threshold.

Respondent profile

Respondents were senior leaders across general management, technology, finance and commercial functions within the AMP 210 cohort, surveyed in 2026. Individual companies,

industries and locations are not identified, and no respondent is named or quoted by name anywhere in this report.

Key findings

Measure	Count	Percent or score
Half or fewer initiatives fully delivered expected commercial outcomes	43 of 82	52.4%
Technology selected before business outcome at least half the time	54 of 82	65.9%
Technology selected first more often than not or almost always	40 of 82	48.8%
Organizational readiness assessed before capital committed	16 of 82	19.5%
Method for measuring value defined in advance	16 of 82	19.5%
Dedicated ownership and resources	19 of 80	23.8%
Incentives redesigned to support the initiative	6 of 82	7.3%
Strong, clearly named executive ownership	22 of 82	26.8%
Verified commercial-return score (1 to 10 scale)	82	Mean 5.2, median 5

Detailed results and observed relationships

Comparison	Observed result	Statistical note
Dedicated ownership vs business as usual	26.3% vs 2.9% full delivery, 9.2x	Fisher exact p=.0168 (5 of 19 vs 1 of 35). Strong observed association; small groups; not causal proof.
Dedicated vs shared ownership	26.3% vs 4.5%, 5.8x	Fisher exact p=.0795 (5 of 19 vs 1 of 22). Directional; not conventionally significant.
Incentives redesigned vs no change	50% vs 20% reporting at least half delivered, 2.5x	Fisher exact p=.1506; redesigned group n=6. Exploratory only.
Zero key conditions vs at least one	0 of 32 vs 7 of 50 fully delivered	Fisher exact p=.0391. Observed sample difference; avoid universal claims.
Number of conditions present vs verified-return score	Spearman rho=.424	p<.001. Moderate positive association; not causal proof.

All statistical comparisons are two-sided Fisher exact tests or a Spearman rank correlation, run against the final 82-response dataset. These describe observed associations within this sample and should not be read as proof of causation.

Anonymous interview themes

The initiative described as successful had a clearer connection to the business objective, stronger accountability, and more disciplined attention to adoption and measurable outcomes. The initiative that underperformed reflected a gap between the intended strategy and the operating conditions required to execute it: a business case had been approved, but ownership, resourcing and the definition of value stayed unresolved after launch. Because the conversations were tailored and the sample was limited, they should be read as explanatory rather than independent proof.

Comparison with external research

McKinsey's 2025 State of AI survey found more than 80% of respondents were not seeing a tangible enterprise-level EBIT impact from generative AI, with workflow redesign showing the largest effect among the attributes it tested. Deloitte's January 2025 State of Generative AI in the Enterprise research found more than two-thirds of respondents expected 30% or fewer of their experiments to be fully scaled within three to six months, while nearly three-quarters said their most advanced initiative was meeting or exceeding ROI expectations. PwC's 2026 Global CEO Survey found 56% of CEOs reported neither higher revenue nor lower costs from AI during the prior year, while 12% reported both. Together, these studies reinforce the need to distinguish experimentation, adoption and isolated use-case performance from verified enterprise value.

Leadership implications

Readiness means diagnosing where today's norms, power, and incentives will resist tomorrow's strategy, and adjusting them before capital is committed. The framework I apply is the LEASH model, developed by Charles O'Reilly of Stanford: leader actions, employee involvement, aligned rewards, stories and symbols, and HR systems. Where the diagnostic finds gaps, these five levers close them.

Technology Investment Risk Checklist

One missing condition does not guarantee failure, but every unresolved condition increases execution risk.

- The business outcome was not clearly defined before the technology was selected.
- The initiative lacks visible sponsorship from a senior leader with sufficient authority.
- Leadership is not aligned that the initiative is an enterprise priority.
- No executive is financially accountable for the value outcome.
- The operating model, decision rights or ownership are ambiguous.
- Employees are expected to deliver the transformation in addition to unchanged full-time responsibilities.
- The initiative lacks dedicated or protected resources.

- Existing incentives continue to reward legacy priorities and behaviors.
- Workflows, dependencies, frontline requirements or data flows have not been mapped adequately.
- Required capabilities are missing or unavailable.
- Governance tracks activity and delivery but not adoption and value.
- Progress is inconsistent, costs are escalating or the expected return cannot be verified.

CEO and Board Technology Investment Review

Approval and readiness

- Business hypothesis and the commercial outcome being funded
- Accountable business owner and financial responsibility
- Dedicated team versus existing resources, and what is stopped or deferred if resources are shared
- Tasks, workflows, interdependencies, systems and data mapped
- Required capabilities and an accountable project leader
- Formal structure, decision rights and governance process
- Incentives and cultural signals aligned with the new priority
- Access and organizational authority to investigate and act

Governance and value verification

- Proof of value that will justify further investment
- Milestones for delivery, adoption and business value
- Metrics that measure delivery, adoption and business value separately
- How the business owner will demonstrate value and how Finance will verify it
- Assumptions most likely to be wrong
- Conditions that would trigger pause, redesign or stop
- What must be true before the initiative is scaled

- Who owns continuous optimization after implementation

Do not assign a numerical score or failure threshold. The study did not validate one. This tool is meant to prompt disciplined judgment rather than imply a diagnostic certainty the evidence does not support.

Decision guide for underperforming initiatives

A missed milestone or modest cost increase does not necessarily justify stopping an initiative. The greater concern is a pattern of missed milestones, escalating costs or weak adoption combined with unresolved conditions that were already identifiable. When delivery problems confirm previously visible readiness risks, leadership should pause additional investment and conduct a structured diagnosis, then decide to continue, correct, redesign, scale or stop.

Conclusion and contact invitation

Commission an independent diagnostic before approving more capital. If your organization is investing in data, digital transformation, technology or AI and is not seeing the expected progress or financial return, I can help determine what is preventing the initiative from creating value, right-size the investment and operating model, and lead the work through implementation and verified results. I am available for select full-time executive leadership, interim leadership and advisory mandates.

Email zacharyleifer@gmail.com or visit zacharyleifer.com.

References and suggested citation

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About the author

Zachary Leifer is a Las Vegas-based commercial growth and transformation executive who has served as Chief Marketing Officer at 1/ST Technology, Chief Commercial Officer at PokerAtlas, a B2B SaaS and B2C gaming platform, and Vice President of Corporate Information Technology at Las Vegas Sands, giving him experience on both sides of transformation. Through State of Mind Strategies, he advises leadership teams on commercial growth, customer data, transformation, technology strategy and AI value creation. He completed the Harvard Business School Advanced Management Program in 2026.

